



An unpopular theory

People made fun of Darwin for his ideas; he was drawn with the body of a chimpanzee in 1871 when he proposed that humans were related to apes.

▼ ARCHAEOPTERYX

had feathers but also teeth, claws, and a tail like those of dinosaurs.



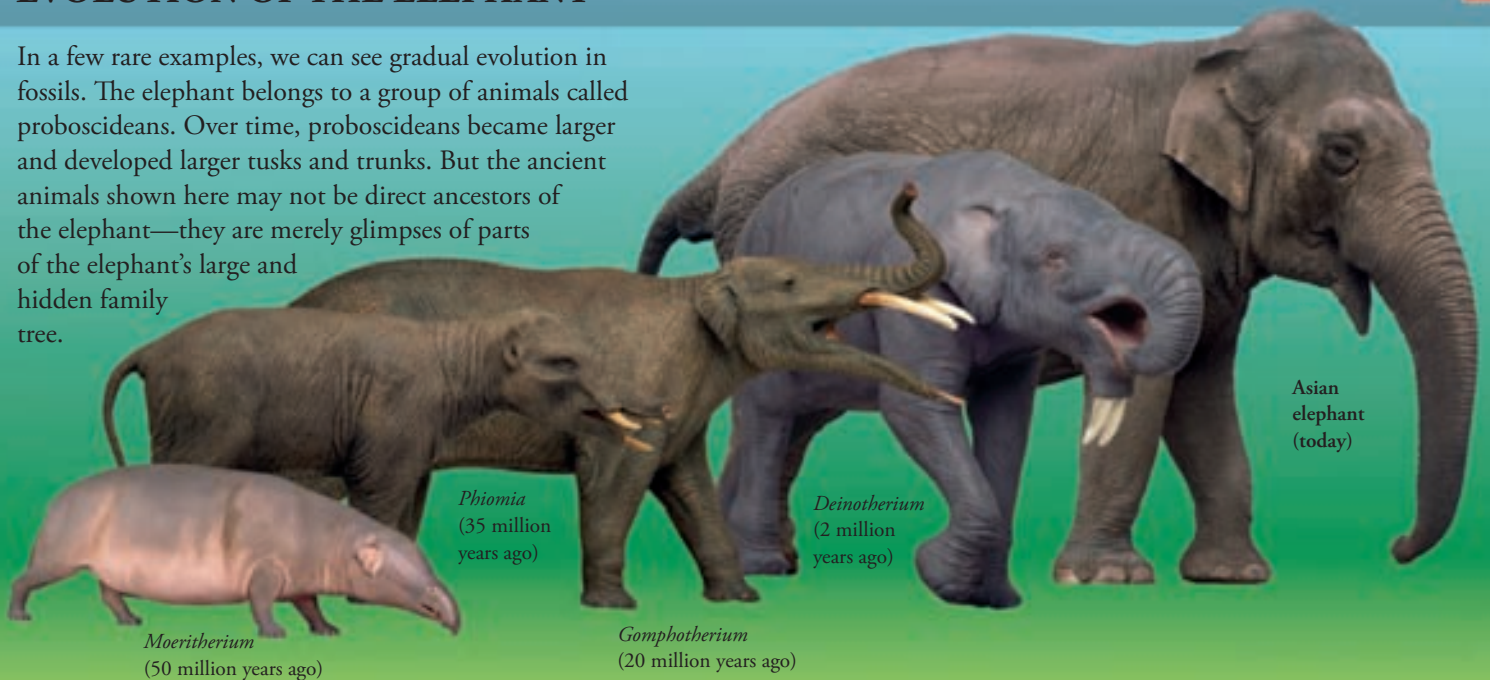
FOSSIL EVIDENCE

One reason Darwin was ridiculed is that the fossil record is much too sparse to show a process of gradual change. However, some key fossils show clear links between related animal groups. One example is *Archaeopteryx*—a missing link between dinosaurs and birds.



EVOLUTION OF THE ELEPHANT

In a few rare examples, we can see gradual evolution in fossils. The elephant belongs to a group of animals called proboscideans. Over time, proboscideans became larger and developed larger tusks and trunks. But the ancient animals shown here may not be direct ancestors of the elephant—they are merely glimpses of parts of the elephant's large and hidden family tree.



Asian elephant (today)

Artificial selection

Darwin realized that animal breeders change their breeds using a process very similar to natural selection. Instead of letting nature choose which animals will breed, breeders make the choice themselves. Darwin called this artificial selection. All dog breeds were created this way from their wild ancestor, the wolf.



Gray wolf

▼ DOGS All domestic dogs today have a common ancestor in the wolf.

